01

TERMINOLOGY, CHRONOLOGY AND THE INTEGRATION-LOCALISATION MODEL — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Terminology, Chronology And The Integration-Localisation Model — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Terminology to Chronology, then testing the relationship through The Integration-Localisation Model and Early Harappan.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
The tripartite scheme describes processes, not three sealed ethnic populations.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Protohistory here means a literate civilization whose script cannot yet be read.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: mature Harappan and Rig Vedic are contemporaneous. || Mature Harappan urbanism largely predates the...

ANSWER LINE: “Harappan” is the safest archaeological label because the culture extended far beyond the Indus valley and the identification of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati remains debated.

02

DISCOVERY, EXCAVATION AND CHANGING HISTORIOGRAPHY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Discovery, Excavation And Changing Historiography is analysed by relating Discovery to Excavation, then testing the relationship through Changing Historiography and Marshall.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Research moved from spectacular citadels and artefacts toward households, villages, plant and animal remains, human biology, provenance and environmental histories.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
New methods have not removed interpretation; they have made the evidentiary chain more explicit.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: the first excavator's label proves a structure's function. || Labels must be retested against...

ANSWER LINE: Historiography is a movement from diffusion, monarchy and invasion toward indigenous development, regional variation and multidisciplinary process.

03

GEOGRAPHICAL EXTENT, ECOLOGICAL ZONES AND REGIONAL DOMAINS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Geographical Extent, Ecological Zones And Regional Domains — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Geographical Extent to Ecological Zones, then testing the relationship through Regional Domains and Indus alluvium.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Use “vast, multi-ecological zone” rather than one immutable boundary.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Shortughai in Afghanistan was an isolated trading outpost.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: Indus Valley Civilization means all sites lie in the Indus valley. || The distribution...

ANSWER LINE: Ecological diversity explains both civilizational resilience and regionally varied pathways of decline.

04

FROM EARLIER FARMING COMMUNITIES TO EARLY HARAPPAN URBAN POTENTIAL

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, From Earlier Farming Communities To Early Harappan Urban Potential is analysed by relating Kot Diji to Fortification, citadel-lower area, wheel-made pottery and copper, then testing the relationship through Planning and hierarchy preceded mature cities and Rehman Dheri.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Explain origins as endogenous transformation with inter-regional interaction, not a Mesopotamian colony or one-site diffusion.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that explain origins as endogenous transformation with inter-regional interaction, not a Mesopotamian colony or one-site...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: early Harappan means primitive and unplanned. || Several early settlements were fortified, planned and...

ANSWER LINE: Urbanisation emerged through convergence among regional traditions, craft intensification, exchange, agricultural surplus, leadership and ideology; no single trigger is sufficient.

05

SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY AND THE URBAN-RURAL SYSTEM — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
The civilization was urban, but most settlements were villages.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
The civilization was urban, but most settlements were villages.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Allahdino was a small village with precious ornaments, showing that wealth was not confined to great cities.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: urban civilization means every Harappan settlement was a city. || The settlement network was...

ANSWER LINE: Standardisation across this hierarchy required coordination, but it does not by itself prove one centralized empire.

06

SITE ATLAS I - HARAPPA AND MOHENJO-DARO — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Pair the two sites to show shared standards plus different public landscapes.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Mohenjo-daro may have had over 700 wells, including private and neighbourhood wells.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Its secure significance is collective engineering; ritual bathing is plausible, not proven.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: the Great Bath proves a named religion. || It proves sophisticated waterproof public architecture.

ANSWER LINE: Pair the two sites to show shared standards plus different public landscapes.

07

SITE ATLAS II - DHOLAVIRA AND RAKHIGARHI — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Site Atlas Ii - Dholavira And Rakhigarhi — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Site Atlas Ii - Dholavira to Rakhigarhi, then testing the relationship through Dholavira and Regional adaptation, water governance and civic writing.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
It demonstrates civic display of writing but does not reveal the city's name until the script is deciphered.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that dholavira supplies architecture and climate adaptation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Rakhigarhi DNA settled every question of Harappan identity. || One low-coverage ancient genome was a major beginning, not a complete population history.

ANSWER LINE: Dholavira supplies architecture and climate adaptation; Rakhigarhi supplies urban, mortuary and scientific evidence.

08

SITE ATLAS III - KALIBANGAN, LOTHAL AND BANAWALI — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Site Atlas Iii - Kalibangan, Lothal And Banawali — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Site Atlas Iii - Kalibangan to Lothal, then testing the relationship through Banawali and Kalibangan.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Kalibangan's lower town lacked the Mohenjo-daro type street drains; household wastewater could empty into jars or troughs outside.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
This is regional variation, not urban failure.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: every fire installation proves Vedic ritual continuity. || Shape, context, chronology and associated remains...

ANSWER LINE: Site Atlas Iii - Kalibangan, Lothal And Banawali — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] comprises Site Atlas Iii - Kalibangan, Lothal and Banawali as its core connected dimensions.

09

SITE ATLAS IV - SURKOTADA, CHANHUDARO AND OTHER STRATEGIC SITES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Horse remains are rare and disputed; the mature civilization was not horse-centred.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Horse remains are rare and disputed; the mature civilization was not horse-centred.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The humped bull and cattle economy are much more characteristic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: a reported horse bone makes the horse a defining Harappan animal. || Identification, context...

ANSWER LINE: Chanhudaro proves that major craft production could occur in a town without the monumental form of Mohenjo-daro.

10

TOWN PLANNING, ARCHITECTURE AND BUILT STANDARDS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Town Planning, Architecture And Built Standards — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Town Planning to Architecture, then testing the relationship through Built Standards and Brick standard.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Houses usually opened into side lanes and were arranged around courtyards.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Baked bricks were concentrated in drains, wells, baths and important structures at many sites; mud-brick remained fundamental.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: planned layout means every city followed one blueprint. || Dholavira, Kalibangan, Lothal and smaller...

ANSWER LINE: Town Planning, Architecture And Built Standards — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] comprises Town Planning, Architecture and Built Standards as its core connected dimensions.

11

WATER, SANITATION, DRAINAGE AND COLLECTIVE MAINTENANCE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Infrastructure required repeated maintenance by workers whose social position is archaeologically under-visible.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Infrastructure required repeated maintenance by workers whose social position is archaeologically under-visible.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Sewage channels and rainwater collection were not necessarily the same system.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: drains prove modern public health ideas. || They prove practical sanitation and engineering.

ANSWER LINE: Water management is a bounded contemporary bridge to urban resilience, not proof that ancient institutions were identical to modern municipalities.

12

PUBLIC STRUCTURES, CRAFT ZONES AND THE PROBLEM OF FUNCTIONAL LABELS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Public buildings reveal labour mobilisation, but the responsible institution could have been rulers, councils, merchants, ritual specialists or combined authorities.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Public buildings reveal labour mobilisation, but the responsible institution could have been rulers, councils, merchants, ritual specialists or combined authorities.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Use quotation marks around contested labels in Mains answers.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: a large building is automatically a palace, temple or state warehouse. || Function requires...

ANSWER LINE: Craft areas are better identified when raw material, waste, tools, unfinished pieces and furnaces occur together.

13

AGRICULTURE, CROPS, SEASONS AND FOOD SURPLUS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Agriculture, Crops, Seasons And Food Surplus — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Agriculture to Crops, then testing the relationship through Seasons and Food Surplus.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Shortughai has canal evidence; Allahdino irrigation from wells is suggested but not conclusive.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that agriculture was the mainstay, but crop packages varied regionally.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: no surviving ploughshare means no ploughing. || Furrows and terracotta plough models support wooden-plough...

ANSWER LINE: Agriculture was the mainstay, but crop packages varied regionally.

14

PASTORALISM, MEAT, DAIRY, FISHING AND ENVIRONMENTAL RESOURCE USE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Pastoralism, Meat, Dairy, Fishing And Environmental Resource Use is analysed by relating Pastoralism to Meat, then testing the relationship through Dairy and Fishing.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Cattle and buffalo were central; sheep, goats, pigs, dogs and cats also occur.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The horse is rare, debated and not characteristic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: an animal on a seal was necessarily domesticated or worshipped. || Representation can be...

ANSWER LINE: Pastoralism, Meat, Dairy, Fishing And Environmental Resource Use comprises Pastoralism, Meat and Dairy as its core connected dimensions.

15

CRAFT PRODUCTION, METALLURGY AND TECHNICAL SKILL — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
The bronze “Dancing Girl” was made by lost-wax casting.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
The bronze “Dancing Girl” was made by lost-wax casting.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that pure copper objects were more numerous than bronze objects.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: bronze Age means every tool was bronze. || Copper, bronze, stone, shell, bone, wood...

ANSWER LINE: Pure copper objects were more numerous than bronze objects; alloys were selected especially where harder edges were useful.

16

ART AND MATERIAL CULTURE - SCULPTURE, POTTERY, TERRACOTTAS AND TOYS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Differences in materials, skill and distribution may reflect audience, function and access, not a simple high-art/low-art hierarchy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Differences in materials, skill and distribution may reflect audience, function and access, not a simple high-art/low-art hierarchy.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that seals are among the finest artistic products.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
A modern museum nickname is an ancient identity. || Use the nickname for recall but state its interpretive status.

ANSWER LINE: Seals are among the finest artistic products, but terracottas range from carefully modelled to quickly made objects for everyday or short-term use.

17

WEIGHTS, MEASURES, GEOMETRY AND EVIDENCE OF SCIENTIFIC KNOWLEDGE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
The 2026 Prelims PYQ correctly treats weights and graduated scales as evidence of scientific knowledge, while rejecting a property-system inference from house form.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Standardization could arise through state regulation, merchant coordination, hereditary specialists, exchange networks or combinations of these.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Smaller units follow a binary progression, while higher units include decimal relationships.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: “Multiple of 16” alone describes the whole weight system. || Smaller and larger series...

ANSWER LINE: The 2026 Prelims PYQ correctly treats weights and graduated scales as evidence of scientific knowledge, while rejecting a property-system inference from house form.

18

SEALS, SEALINGS AND THE UNDECIPHERED SCRIPT — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Textile impressions on some sealings support authentication of goods, but seals also show wear and suspension holes consistent with other functions.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Script non-decipherment is the master limitation governing claims about rulers, institutions and beliefs.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Do not use the whole script boustrophedon.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: a proposed Dravidian, Sanskrit or non-linguistic reading is settled. || Competing proposals exist.

ANSWER LINE: Textile impressions on some sealings support authentication of goods, but seals also show wear and suspension holes consistent with other functions.

19

INTERNAL EXCHANGE, RAW MATERIALS AND TRANSPORT — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Internal Exchange, Raw Materials And Transport — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Internal Exchange to Raw Materials, then testing the relationship through Transport and Copper.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Two-wheeled carts with solid wheels, pack animals, river boats and seagoing craft are supported by models, tracks and depictions.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that internal exchange was more structurally important than the visually attractive but limited Mesopotamian trade.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: a non-local bead proves conquest or colony. || It proves movement.

ANSWER LINE: Internal exchange was more structurally important than the visually attractive but limited Mesopotamian trade.

20

LONG-DISTANCE TRADE, MELUHHA AND THE MESOPOTAMIAN LINK — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Possible exports include carnelian beads, textiles, shell and ivory; possible imports include selected metals and luxury materials.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Possible exports include carnelian beads, textiles, shell and ivory; possible imports include selected metals and luxury materials.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Dilmun and Magan were intermediating regions, not Harappan cities.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Mesopotamian trade caused Harappan urbanism. || It may have enriched exchange, but chronology and low find quantities undermine a monocausal claim.

ANSWER LINE: Dilmun is generally identified with Bahrain; Magan with Oman/Makran; Meluhha probably included the Indus region but its exact scope is debated.

21

SOCIAL ORGANISATION, WEALTH AND OCCUPATIONAL DIVERSITY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Rank and class differences probably existed, but claims of a Harappan caste system are highly speculative.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Rank and class differences probably existed, but claims of a Harappan caste system are highly speculative.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Material culture can suggest inequality more securely than it can name legal status.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: house size, location, craft access, ornaments, hoards, diet and burials indicate differentiation.

ANSWER LINE: House size, location, craft access, ornaments, hoards, diet and burials indicate differentiation, but there are no royal tombs or lavish elite burials comparable to Egypt and Mesopotamia.

22

POLITY DEBATE - EMPIRE, CITY-STATES, COUNCILS OR CORPORATE ELITES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Polity Debate - Empire, City-States, Councils Or Corporate Elites is analysed by relating Polity Debate - Empire to City-States, then testing the relationship through Councils Or Corporate Elites and Centralized empire.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
The most defensible position is organized authority with uncertain scale, personnel and coercive structure.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Achievement is clear; constitutional form is not.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
No palace means no state. || Early states can express authority through infrastructure, standards and networks rather than royal monuments.

ANSWER LINE: Polity Debate - Empire, City-States, Councils Or Corporate Elites comprises Polity Debate - Empire, City-States and Councils Or Corporate Elites as its core connected dimensions.

23

RELIGION AND RITUAL - INTERPRETATION WITHOUT BACK-PROJECTION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Religious interpretation should follow the sequence form - context - comparison - alternative - qualified conclusion.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Religious interpretation should follow the sequence form - context - comparison - alternative - qualified conclusion.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Female figurines are abundant at some sites and rare at others, demonstrating regional or functional variation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: similarity with later Hindu practice proves direct unchanged continuity. || Resemblance may indicate continuity...

ANSWER LINE: Harappan ritual was plural, household and civic; a single standardized creed cannot be reconstructed.

24

GENDER, BURIALS, HEALTH AND THE LIMITS OF SOCIAL RECONSTRUCTION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Burial wealth was generally modest compared with Egyptian or Mesopotamian royal tombs.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Burial wealth was generally modest compared with Egyptian or Mesopotamian royal tombs.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that use burial and gender evidence as a lesson in cautious social history, not a...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: goddess worship means matriarchy. || Divine femininity and ordinary women's authority are separate questions.

ANSWER LINE: Use burial and gender evidence as a lesson in cautious social history, not a route to confident family law.

25

DECLINE AND DEURBANISATION - A MULTI-CAUSAL, REGIONAL PROCESS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Decline And Deurbanisation - A Multi-Causal, Regional Process — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Decline to Deurbanisation - A Multi-Causal, then testing the relationship through Regional Process and Aryan invasion.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
The mature phase was followed by Late Harappan cultures; people and practices did not vanish.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Mohenjo-daro and Dholavira show gradual deterioration, while urban life ended more abruptly at Kalibangan and Banawali.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: one flood, one invasion or one drought ended every city. || Different mechanisms operated...

ANSWER LINE: Use “metamorphosis/deurbanisation” with causation, regional variation and continuity.

26

LATE HARAPPAN CONTINUITY, TRANSFORMATION AND SUCCESSOR CULTURES — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Late Harappan levels overlap with Painted Grey Ware at some Punjab-Haryana sites and with Ochre Coloured Pottery in western Uttar Pradesh.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Late Harappan levels overlap with Painted Grey Ware at some Punjab-Haryana sites and with Ochre Coloured Pottery in western Uttar Pradesh.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Overlap shows contact and sequence, not ethnic identity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: “Continuity” means the entire mature urban system survived unchanged. || Continuity and structural rupture...

ANSWER LINE: Continuity is selective; pottery, crops, craft and population can continue even when cities, script and standardized institutions weaken.

27

RELATIONS WITH NEOLITHIC-CHALCOLITHIC AND VEDIC WORLDS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Relations With Neolithic-Chalcolithic And Vedic Worlds is analysed by relating Relations With Neolithic-Chalcolithic to Vedic Worlds, then testing the relationship through Earlier farming communities and Contemporary Chalcolithic groups.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Migration, admixture and cultural interaction are better models than either violent replacement or timeless ethnic identity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into “nothing is known.”

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
aDNA can label an archaeological culture as a modern ethnic or linguistic group. || Genes, language, material culture and political identity are related but non-identical evidence domains.

ANSWER LINE: Relations With Neolithic-Chalcolithic And Vedic Worlds comprises Relations With Neolithic-Chalcolithic, Vedic Worlds and Earlier farming communities as its core connected dimensions.

28

PHASE -> PROCESS -> REGIONAL CHANGE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Phase - Process - Regional Change — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Phase - Process - Regional Change to Mature, then testing the relationship through Late Harappan and It.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Use Early, Mature and Late Harappan as a process sequence: regional foundations - integrated urban traits - de-urbanisation and localisation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
It is not sudden appearance then extinction.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

ANSWER LINE: Mature urbanism is the core factual phase; Late Harappan continuity prevents a one-line collapse story.

29

SITE-FEATURE TRIADS, NOT A SITE CATALOGUE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
The operative mechanism is that a modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that a modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: a modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

ANSWER LINE: A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

30

URBAN WATER AND BUILT FORM — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
They do not securely identify kings, a palace, a granary or one central state.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
They do not securely identify kings, a palace, a granary or one central state.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: they do not securely identify kings, a palace, a granary or one central state.

ANSWER LINE: Grid streets, standard bricks, wells, bathing floors and covered drains securely show planned civic construction and water management.

31

PRODUCTION, MEASUREMENT AND EXCHANGE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
No coinage is known; weights and commodities do not tell us the title of a ruler.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
No coinage is known; weights and commodities do not tell us the title of a ruler.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: evidence of coordination - craft/exchange implication - limit on exact political control.

ANSWER LINE: The argument should be: evidence of coordination - craft/exchange implication - limit on exact political control.

32

SCRIPT, RITUAL AND AUTHORITY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Seals, figurines, fire installations, burials and monumental-looking buildings can reveal material practice and repeated symbols; they cannot securely disclose doctrine, named gods, caste or a monarchy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Seals, figurines, fire installations, burials and monumental-looking buildings can reveal material practice and repeated symbols; they cannot securely disclose doctrine, named gods, caste or a monarchy.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Use 'horned figure', 'female figurines' and 'structure conventionally called...' before advancing a cautious interpretation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: a modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

ANSWER LINE: A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

33

DECLINE AS TRANSFORMATION — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The resulting consequence is that river/environmental change, trade disruption and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations, not a settled single...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not miss this limiting distinction: river/environmental change, trade disruption and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations, not a settled single...

ANSWER LINE: River/environmental change, trade disruption and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations, not a settled single cause.

34

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 1: FROM REGIONAL CULTURES TO URBAN INTEGRATION — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
The Mature phase shows their unusually wide integration: shared seals, weights, brick conventions and urban features.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Shared weights and brick conventions are outcomes of repeated choices and coordination; they are not the initial cause of every town.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
The Late phase is the weakening of this particular urban integration, not the disappearance of every person or practice.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Dholavira's distinctive architecture also demonstrates that integration did not erase regional solutions.

ANSWER LINE: The Mature phase shows their unusually wide integration: shared seals, weights, brick conventions and urban features.

35

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 2: EXTENT, ECOLOGY AND THE URBAN-RURAL SYSTEM — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Ecology creates possibilities and pressures; it does not mechanically determine a political outcome.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
A coastal or semi-arid site should not be judged by the same expectations as a riverine city.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Extent is an economic map: river plains, coast and resource zones were connected, not identical.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Cities therefore depended on villages, pastoral areas and resource routes; they were not self-sufficient islands.

ANSWER LINE: Ecology creates possibilities and pressures; it does not mechanically determine a political outcome.

36

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 3: PLANNING, WATER AND EVERYDAY MAINTENANCE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Deep Teaching Unit 3: Planning, Water And Everyday Maintenance — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Deep Teaching Unit 3 to Planning, then testing the relationship through Water and Everyday Maintenance.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
They do not reveal whether a monarch, council, merchant group or several local authorities organised it.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Calling a raised sector a “citadel” does not prove that it was a royal fort.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
The label describes an excavator's interpretation, not a text from the inhabitants.

ANSWER LINE: Town planning means more than a grid seen from above.

37

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 4: THE ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
Technically, Deep Teaching Unit 4: The Economy As A Linked System — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Deep Teaching Unit 4 to The Economy As A Linked System, then testing the relationship through A bead and Its.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Its raw material had to arrive, specialist labour had to shape it, and finished goods had to move or be exchanged.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
A bead is not just an ornament for a list.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Do not learn crops, beads, weights and trade as disconnected lists.

ANSWER LINE: A Mains paragraph can argue: specialised production and shared metrology indicate an integrated economy, but neither coins nor a named bureaucracy are available to prove a modern market or empire.

38

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 5: EVIDENCE LADDER FOR SCRIPT, POLITY, SOCIETY AND RELIGION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
The same object can sit at different levels of the ladder.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
Use a two-step sentence: “The evidence indicates X because of Y; however, Z remains unresolved because the script is undeciphered and the label is interpretive.” This earns analysis without evasiveness.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
“Undeciphered script” does not license every speculation; it makes the material context more important, not less.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
Archaeology does not mean “we know nothing”; it means that the strength of a claim changes with the evidence.

ANSWER LINE: Because the script is undeciphered, they cannot securely name a king, identify a god, translate a law or establish caste.

39

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 6: DE-URBANISATION AS CAUSAL SEQUENCE AND CONTINUITY — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
A 20-marker should move from what changed (urban traits, settlement pattern) - possible interacting causes - regional unevenness - continuity.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
A 20-marker should move from what changed (urban traits, settlement pattern) - possible interacting causes - regional unevenness - continuity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
It is not a licence to choose one dramatic event.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
A river shift or trade change may help explain them, but needs matching chronology and regional context.

ANSWER LINE: Ghaggar-Hakra debates illustrate the rule: many settlements and changing river/environmental conditions matter, but identification with the Vedic Sarasvati and a civilization-wide causal claim are debated.

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DEEP TEACHING UNIT 7: SITE MEMORY METHOD AND THE FIVE-SENTENCE ANSWER — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE
The method works even when one option is partly familiar.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT
In an unfamiliar site question, do not search memory for one glamorous object.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST
Add a qualifier when a feature is a conventional function, not a settled fact.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE
More sites do not necessarily make a better answer.

ANSWER LINE: Memory improves when a site is stored as a triad rather than an isolated name.